

Newcomer's Guide: Unveiling Canada's Residential Schools

Indigenous History of Canada and Residential School Handout for New Immigrants

MicroGrant Project

Ruhani Jindal

Proposal

My project aims to address the information gap about residential schools among newcomers in Canada. It will depict that even though the last residential school was officially closed down in 1996, racism has persisted. I chose this topic because I believe many new immigrants in Canada do not know about our country's painful history. Many people think of Canada as this tranquil nation that provided refuge to war refugees and has a highly welcoming culture. While these things are all true and wonderful, Canada is not as perfect as many people believe. This is extremely important especially in a place like my hometown, Winnipeg, where the European settlers and First Nations people traded for many years. This aligns with GLOCAL's goal to "foster a dynamic and inclusive community while serving as an incubator for social innovation and youth participation," as my project will raise awareness and remove prejudice about Indigenous people among refugees and immigrants. It will try to reduce misinformation that is widespread about indigenous cultures and educate new immigrants about the positive aspects of indigenous culture, while raising awareness about residential schools, generational trauma, colonization, and genocide.

Purpose

In my conversations with my extended family who recently immigrated to Canada, I realized that they have an ambiguous understanding about many of the current issues which surface on social media channels through posts of unverified sources. One of the most prominent among these issues is the topic of unmarked graves in residential schools. Newcomers to Canada hear about these stories sometimes while crossing an ongoing protest, an Indigenous ceremony being carried out at a historical location near their workplace, or sometimes as a casual conversation between multiple other uninformed people. The latter is usually what spreads prejudice in their minds. I have been asked by many such family members about the most basic topics surrounding residential schools. Since I was taught these subjects from a very young age, I was taken aback by the information gaps among newcomers.

These were my observations:

1. There are many newcomers in Canada who have incomplete and unverified information about residential schools
2. They are inquisitive to learn more about this subject
3. However, they are unable to find the time or means to gain accurate information

At that point, I understood that there is a need among newcomers for education and awareness around residential schools but the resource for this must be concise, interesting, easy to understand, and readily available.

I aimed to have these traits in my brochure. My brochure has an orange theme which represents the day of truth and reconciliation which is also known as orange shirt day. I used a question and answer format to make it easy to read and understand. The brochure is concise, consisting of just one double-sided page. The pictures represent the pain in residential schools and give the viewer a visual of the schools.

Canada is a country which is proudly full of immigrants and is a safe place for refugees. It is an amazing country which promotes equality for everyone and is extremely diverse. This is why many people immigrate to Canada. The issue arises when they fail to acknowledge the responsibility towards reconciliation that each and every Canadian has. They do not realize that the moment they step foot into Canada and claim it as their new

home, there is a huge weight of reconciliation suddenly placed on their shoulders. Some people do realize this but find it difficult to become clear of biases and gain access to accurate information. This indicates why this brochure is so crucial. They must understand this responsibility and work on it.

Future Plan

If I receive a grant, I aim to use it to print and distribute my handout to new immigrants through various channels like information booths at newcomer centers in various cities of Canada. I will also conduct further research on this topic. I will conduct surveys to see how effective my brochure is. Based on the success of this handout, I will start working on more handouts on different Canadian issues for newcomers.

Research

In this section, I am including in-text citations with the information for my brochure to properly cite all my work.

Definitions

Indigenous people: The people who originally lived in Canada. Aboriginal creation stories claim that these lands have always been home to their ancestors. Archaeologists estimate that humans have lived in what is now Canada for at least 12,000 years, and most likely much longer (Government of Canada, 2018).

Settlers: In this document, the term settlers will refer to anyone living in Canada who is not Indigenous.

Indian Act: The primary law the federal government uses to administer Indian status, local First Nations governments and the management of reserve land (The Canadian Encyclopedia, n.d.).

Residential Schools: Schools that were created by Christian churches and the Canadian government as an attempt to both educate and convert Indigenous youth and to assimilate them into Canadian society (The Canadian Encyclopedia, n.d.).

Truth and Reconciliation Commission: This will be referred to as TRC. A commission that investigated the policies and operations of residential schools (The Canadian Encyclopedia, n.d.). They also provide platforms for residential schools to share their stories and inform Canadians about the past.

This timeline has points I didn't include in my brochure but I am citing them because I used this information for my Q&A section.

Timeline

1831: Mohawk Indian Residential School opens in Brantford, Ontario (NCTR, 2023).

1876: The Indian Act is enacted. It contains a number of clauses that allow the federal government to establish Indian Residential Schools (Government of Canada; Crown-

Indigenous Relations and Northern Affairs Canada, 2015). It also gives the Government the exclusive right to create legislation regarding Indians and Indian lands. This Act identifies who is an Indian and establishes related legal rights (NCTR, 2023).

July 01, 1883: Sir John A. Macdonald authorizes the creation of residential schools in the Canadian West (NCTR, 2023).

1885: Amendment to the Indian Act - traditional Indigenous ceremonies, such as potlaches and the Sun Dance, are prohibited. (NCTR, 2023).

1907: After visiting 35 residential schools, Dr. Peter Henderson Bryce, chief medical officer for Canada's Department of the Interior and Indian Affairs (1904–21), reveals that Indigenous children are dying at alarming rates – with the mortality rate of enrolled students as high as 25 per cent. This number climbs to 69 per cent after students leave school. (The Canadian Encyclopedia, n.d.). He also reports that health conditions in residential schools are a “national crime” (NCTR, 2023).

1920: Attendance at residential schools is made mandatory for every First Nations child between 7 and 16 years of age (The Canadian Encyclopedia, n.d.).

1951: Major revisions are made to the Indian Act – women are allowed to participate in band democracy, prohibitions on traditional Aboriginal practices and ceremonies are removed (NCTR, 2023).

1961: Amendment to the Indian Act – Status Indians can vote without having to give up their status (NCTR, 2023).

1982: The Constitution Act is amended and now recognizes and affirms the rights of “Indian, Inuit, and Métis peoples of Canada” (NCTR, 2023).

1986: The United Church of Canada formally apologizes to Canada's First Nations people (CBC, 2014).

1991: The Missionary Oblates of Mary Immaculate offers an apology to Canada's First Nations people (CBC, 2014).

November 1996: The last federally run residential school, Gordon Residential School, shuts down (CBC, 2014).

2001: In order to create a compensation plan, the Canadian government starts talks with the Presbyterian, United, Catholic, and Anglican churches. The government consents to pay former students with verified claims 70% of the settlement by October. (CBC, 2014).

June 11, 2008: Prime Minister Stephen Harper apologizes to former students of native residential schools, marking the first formal apology by a prime minister for the federally financed program (CBC, 2014).

2009: Truth and Reconciliation Commission (TRC) is launched and hosts events all across the country to listen to Canadians who want to share their residential school stories (NCTR, 2023).

2010: First TRC National event held in Winnipeg, Manitoba.

May 2, 2021: The remains of 215+ children were found around the former Kamloops Indian Residential School in British Columbia's Interior (Ministry of Indigenous Relations and Reconciliation, 2023)

2021-2022: Many remains were found in residential schools throughout Canada. In June 2021, the Government of Canada passed Bill C-5 to make September 30 a federal statutory day (Ministry of Indigenous Relations and Reconciliation, 2023). September 30th is also known as orange shirt day.

Works Cited

- A timeline of residential schools, the Truth and Reconciliation Commission. (2014, March 25). CBC. <https://www.cbc.ca/news/canada/a-timeline-of-residential-schools-the-truth-and-reconciliation-commission-1.724434>.
- Government of Canada. (2018, April 3). *Warfare In Pre-Columbian North America*. Canada.ca. <https://www.canada.ca/en/departement-national-defence/services/military-history/history-heritage/popular-books/aboriginal-people-canadian-military/warfare-pre-columbian-north-america.html>.
- Government of Canada; Crown-Indigenous Relations and Northern Affairs Canada. (2015, May 27). *Timeline - Indian residential schools*. <https://www.rcaanc-cirnac.gc.ca/eng/1332939430258/1571587651162>.
- Indian Act*. (n.d.). The Canadian Encyclopedia. <https://www.thecanadianencyclopedia.ca/en/article/indian-act>.
- Ministry of Indigenous Relations and Reconciliation. (2023, September 22). *National Day for Truth and Reconciliation - Province of British Columbia*. <https://www2.gov.bc.ca/gov/content/governments/indigenous-people/national-day-for-truth-and-reconciliation>.
- NCTR. (2023, August 10). *Residential school timeline - NCTR*. NCTR - National Centre for Truth and Reconciliation. <https://nctr.ca/exhibits/residential-school-timeline/>.
- Residential Schools | The Canadian Encyclopedia*. (n.d.). <https://www.thecanadianencyclopedia.ca/en/timeline/residential-schools>.
- Residential schools in Canada*. (n.d.). The Canadian Encyclopedia. <https://www.thecanadianencyclopedia.ca/en/article/residential-schools>.

The Canadian Press. (2022, May 18). Timeline of events since finding of unmarked graves in Kamloops. *CTVNews*. <https://www.ctvnews.ca/canada/timeline-of-events-since-finding-of-unmarked-graves-in-kamloops-1.5908292>.

Truth and Reconciliation Commission. (n.d.). The Canadian Encyclopedia. <https://www.thecanadianencyclopedia.ca/en/article/truth-and-reconciliation-commission>.

I want to get rid of the Indian problem... Our objective is to continue until there is not a single Indian in Canada that has not been absorbed into the body politic and there is no Indian question and no Indian Department.”
~Duncan Campbell Scott
(Deputy Superintendent of the Department of Indian Affairs from 1913 to 1932.

This is what Duncan Campbell Scott, deputy superintendent of the Department of Indian Affairs, said while talking about the Indian Act. While reading this quote, it can be noticed that there is little to no respect for the “Indians” who are more commonly known as the Indigenous people of Canada.

For more information, please refer to:

...

National Centre for Truth and Reconciliation:

<https://nctr.ca/>

Government of Canada:

<https://www.canada.ca/en/crown-indigenous-relations-northern-affairs.html>

Canadian Encyclopedia:

<https://www.thecanadianencyclopedia.ca/en/timeline/first-nations>



Residential Schools

The Dark History of Canada

An informational handout
By: Ruhani Jindal

Timeline

Q & A

Q: Why is this relevant today?

A: The history of residential schools is important today because of inter-generational trauma. Indigenous children were forcefully taken away from their families to become part of these residential schools. Separation from families and abuse at the residential schools made the lives of those students traumatic. They could not inherit their family traditions and culture which led to lost identities. The trauma keeps getting passed down to future generations and though residential schools do not exist any more, survivors and their families are still experiencing the harmful impacts caused by those institutions.

Q: What is the meaning of Truth and Reconciliation and how can I contribute?

A: If we do not acknowledge a problem, we cannot find a solution. Truth is acknowledging that there was a human rights violation at the first place. Reconciliation is trying to minimize the impact of the same or, in this case, trying to help out the victims and their families. All we can do is consciously get rid of the subconscious biases toward Indigenous people.



Q: I've heard a lot in the news about children's remains being discovered in unmarked graves. What is happening?

A: These news stories you have been hearing are about children in the residential schools in Canada that existed from 1831 to 1996. There were conversations sparked by the recent discovery of 215 children discovered at the Kamloops residential school, which received significant media attention. The cruelty at these schools is becoming more widely known thanks to these recent discoveries, which have also revived protests and conversations about it.

Q: What were residential schools?

A: They were government-sponsored schools run by churches. They were made in an effort to assimilate Indigenous youth into Canadian society and to educate and convert them.

Q: Who are the Indigenous people of Canada?

A: The Indigenous people of Canada are the people who originally lived on this land. Archaeologists estimate that Indigenous people have lived in what is now Canada for at least 12,000 years, and most likely much longer. They cared for the land for many years before the settlers arrived. Settlers are all Canadians who aren't Indigenous.

1 • 1831

The first Residential School opens in Brantford, Ontario

2 • 1876

The Indian Act grants the government the authority to regulate the laws of Indigenous peoples.

3 • 1883

Sir John A. Macdonald authorizes the creation of residential schools in the Canadian West

4 • 1907

Dr. Peter Bryce reports that health conditions in residential schools are a "national crime"

5 • 1920

Residential schools are made mandatory for every First Nations child ages 7-16

6 • 1961

The Indian Act has been amended to allow Status Indians to vote without giving up their status.

7 • 1982

The Constitution Act now recognizes the rights of the Indigenous peoples of Canada

8 • 1996

The last federally run residential school, Gordon Residential School, shuts down

9 • 2001

The government has agreed to pay survivors 70% of the agreed compensation settlement.

10 • 2009

The Truth and Reconciliation Commission of Canada is launched

11 • 2021

The remains of 215+ children were found near Kamloops Indian Residential School

12 • 2021

September 30th is made a federal statutory day for Truth and Reconciliation